

PROJECT REPORT

SRHR Tech Circles

Safe Digital Spaces for Indigenous Young Women on FGM, Child Marriage and Menstrual Health

Beyond Borders

Indigenous Young Women-Led Collective | Northern Kenya ASAL

Implementation Period: 2023–2024

Focus: Bodily autonomy, confidential information access, peer facilitation

This report documents the establishment of safe digital and peer spaces in which indigenous young women created anonymous audio stories and zines about FGM, child marriage and menstrual health. Three participants progressed to become independent lead facilitators.

1. Executive Summary

Between 2023 and 2024, Beyond Borders established SRHR Tech Circles that reached more than 60 indigenous young women. The circles created confidential, low-tech digital and peer spaces for discussing female genital mutilation (FGM), child marriage and menstrual health. Participants produced anonymous audio stories and zines that could be shared without exposing individuals on shared family phones. Three women who began as participants later became lead facilitators and have independently trained new cohorts.

The work addressed a critical gap: in many ASAL communities there is no safe, culturally relevant channel for young women to access accurate information about their bodies. Shared phones, patriarchal surveillance and information vacuums sustain harmful practices. The circles tested offline-friendly, peer-led methods that prioritise safety and anonymity over high-tech platforms.

60+	3	FGM, child marriage, menstrual health	Audio stories & zines
<i>Young women reached</i>	<i>Lead facilitators emerged</i>	<i>Core themes</i>	<i>Format</i>

2. Background and Rationale

In many pastoralist communities of Northern Kenya, FGM and child marriage remain linked to economic pressure, patriarchal control and limited access to alternative information. Drought and livestock loss can accelerate early marriage as a household coping strategy. Young women seeking information about their bodies face multiple barriers: shared family phones leave digital traces; formal health services are distant or stigmatising; and open discussion of FGM or menstruation can attract social sanction.

Beyond Borders recognised that conventional digital SRHR tools designed for urban, individual smartphone users would not work in this context. The collective therefore designed peer circles that combined face-to-face trust-building with simple digital outputs (anonymous audio and print/zine formats) that could circulate without exposing participants.

3. Objectives

The circles aimed to:

- Create confidential peer spaces where indigenous young women could discuss FGM, child marriage and menstrual health without fear of immediate exposure.
- Support participants to produce anonymous audio stories and simple zines that could be shared safely on shared devices or in print.
- Build practical digital and facilitation skills among participants so that knowledge and methods could continue beyond the initial circles.
- Identify and support emerging facilitators who could lead new cohorts independently.
- Generate learning on what safety, anonymity and cultural relevance require in ASAL digital SRHR work.

4. Approach and Methods

4.1 Circle design

Circles were kept relatively small and grounded in existing relationships. Sessions combined discussion, basic digital skills (audio recording, simple editing, anonymous sharing methods) and creative production of stories and zines. Content was delivered in local languages and Kiswahili as appropriate. Facilitators emphasised that no one was required to disclose personal experience; contribution could take many forms.

4.2 Safety and anonymity measures

Because phones are frequently shared within households, the circles avoided approaches that left visible search histories or personal accounts. Audio stories were recorded and edited so that individual voices and identifying details could be removed or altered. Zines used drawings, collective narratives and non-identifying text. Distribution relied on peer networks and trusted intermediaries rather than public online platforms.

4.3 From participants to facilitators

From the outset the circles included space for participants to practise leading short sessions. Three women who showed consistent engagement, care for group safety and ability to explain content clearly were supported to take on lead facilitator roles. They have since trained new cohorts with reduced direct involvement from the core team, demonstrating a pathway from participant to peer trainer.

5. Key Results and Outcomes

Reach and outputs

- More than 60 indigenous young women participated across the 2023–2024 circles.
- Anonymous audio stories and zines produced on FGM, child marriage and menstrual health.
- Three participants became lead facilitators and have independently trained new groups.

Qualitative outcomes

- Participants reported greater confidence in discussing bodily issues within trusted peer settings.
- The facilitator pathway reduced dependence on the small core team and increased local ownership.
- The circles generated practical learning on how to design SRHR information for shared-device, low-connectivity environments.
- Peer production of content (rather than external messaging) increased relevance and reduced perceptions of outside imposition.

6. Challenges and Lessons Learned

- Safety is collective: Individual “privacy settings” are largely meaningless on shared phones. Design must assume that content may be seen by others and therefore prioritise anonymity and non-identifying formats.
- Stigma and silence are real constraints: Even within peer circles, opening discussion of FGM or child marriage required careful facilitation and clear agreements about confidentiality.
- Low-tech is often more appropriate: Complex apps or online platforms created barriers. Audio and simple print/zine formats travelled further and required less infrastructure.
- Facilitator development takes time: Moving from participant to independent lead facilitator required ongoing mentorship, practice opportunities and attention to the facilitators’ own safety and wellbeing.
- Linking to broader support: Circles could open conversation but could not replace referral pathways for survivors needing protection, medical or psychosocial support. Integration with existing community and organisational referral options remains essential.

7. Contribution to Beyond Borders’ Work

The SRHR Tech Circles formed the practical foundation of the Bodily Autonomy Tech working circle. They demonstrated that peer-led, offline-friendly methods can create safer information spaces and can generate local facilitators. This experience directly informs current plans for offline-first SRHR resource kits in local languages and for scaling peer facilitation rather than centralised delivery.

8. Looking Ahead

Next steps include consolidating the offline SRHR kits (audio, printable and simple digital formats), supporting the existing lead facilitators to train further cohorts, and strengthening links between the circles and community-based referral options. The priority remains safety, anonymity and local ownership rather than rapid numerical scale-up.

This report documents community-led learning and practice. It does not disclose identifying details of participants or survivors. Any use of methods or materials from the circles should prioritise the safety protocols developed with the young women involved.

Beyond Borders | Northern Kenya | 2023–2025